

Desktop environments

KDE

KDE is a network transparent contemporary desktop environment for Unix workstations. KDE seeks to fill the need for an easy-to-use desktop for Unix workstations, similar to the desktop environments found under Macintosh, or Windows.

KDE has the following features:

- A beautiful contemporary desktop
- An integrated help system, allowing for convenient access to help pages of the KDE desktop, and related applications
- Standardised menu and toolbars, keybindings, colour schemes, etc.
- Internationalisation: KDE is available in more than 40 languages
- Centralised dialog driven desktop configuration

KDE applications

KDE has an office application suite, based on KDE's 'Kparts' technology consisting of a spreadsheet, a presentation application, an organiser, a news client, and more. It also includes a Web browser—Konqueror,

which is a solid competitor to other existing Unix Web browsers.

GNOME

GNOME is a powerful graphics-driven desktop environment that enables users to easily use and configure their PCs. It's main objective is to provide a user-friendly suite of applications, and an easy-to-use desktop. It includes a start up panel, a desktop, standard desktop tools and applications, and a set of conventions that make it easy for applications to be consistent with each other.

Window Managers

One of the main distinguishing features of X is that it separates the window manager from the windowing system. X allows you to run any window manager that controls the title bar, and other decorations. You can run a window manager that looks and acts like the NeXT interface, the Motif interface, or the Open Look interface. Common window managers are mentioned in the box below:

Name	Description
fvwm	Looks like mwm; main window manager on Linux
fvwm95	Looks like Windows 95. Comes with Slackware Linux
WindowMaker	Uses NeXT interface.
AfterStep	Follow on to Bowman; uses NeXT interface.
Enlightenment	A color-intensive window manager.

user-friendly for desktop users.

The set up is quite simple. The tricky part is the disk partitioning utility that is not easy for a new user. Though it provides a graphical representation of all the partitions on the hard drive, it does not shield you from assigning a root partition or selecting a swap partition. Otherwise the install can be easily navigated by a user with a basic idea of Linux.

Starting off with Red Hat 8.0, Red Hat has embarked on an ambitious project, called the Blue Curve desktop initiative, that provides a highly integrated desktop environment. This initiative has drawn a lot of flak from the open source community, since it also restricts the ability of the user

info

The older Linux lpd-based printing subsystem has now been replaced by the CUPS subsystem that has a very simple Web-based configuration utility, and supports many standard lpd commands.

to play around with the desktop. Thus, this Blue Curve initiative has removed a lot of the fun that was possible in the earlier versions of Red Hat. But it is a boon to the new user who does not care much about switching desktops and window managers.

Configuring your graphical hardware and adjusting display settings is also much easier now using the new 'redhat-config-xfree86' tool, which has replaced Xconfigurator as the standard tool for

graphical configuration. But, there is a downside to using this new utility, it runs in graphical mode and the only way left to bring the X server to life in case of faulty hardware detection is by tweaking the X server's configuration file.

Red Hat does a good job of compiling applications from source code, and there are no issues as far as support for rpm packages go. But the package management system leaves a lot to be desired,

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